Query Performance Prediction Is Not Benefit Prediction: Observability for Selective Retrieval Interventions

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Abstract

Selective retrieval interventions, such as LLM query expansion (QE), cross-encoder reranking, and pseudo-relevance feedback (PRF), are often gated on a query performance predictor: intervene when retrieval looks like it is failing. We show why failure is the wrong target and measure by how much. Writing the decision as maximizing an intervention's expected gain given observable telemetry, we decompose an oracle selector's gain exactly into gain on failing queries, the most any policy acting only on them can recover, and gain on healthy queries, which it never sees. On TripClick and BEIR NQ, across eight intervention, corpus, and retriever settings, this failure-only ceiling is, without a budget cap, 8–57% of the oracle's gain; a pre-registered runs on two untouched benchmarks give 18–39% (ArguAna) and 28–46% (FiQA), similar at a per-query cost of 0.02. Under a 10% cap (exploratory) it loosens for rescue-rich interventions (to 98% on NQ reranking), yet the failure gate realises at most 24% of the unrestricted oracle's gain at that cap. Detection is ordinary QPP (AUC 0.62–0.70), but against the same benefit label ($\Delta > 0$) it reaches only 0.42–0.56 (exploratory), and 0.46–0.52 against 0.72 in the pre-registered FiQA run. At matched budgets, failure, NQC, and pre-action benefit routing stay near random, and failure routing spends a substantial fraction of its budget on failing queries the intervention leaves unchanged. Exploratory probes of the intervention help on NQ, where routing reranking on cross-encoder scores of ten candidates beats failure routing by +0.024 nDCG@10 at matched fractions and NQC by +0.010 to +0.020 at equal cost, but not on TripClick or ArguAna, nor, pre-registered, on FiQA, where reranking also helps on average.

1 Introduction

Retrieval interventions help some queries and harm others. LLM query expansion (QE) can rewrite a query using the evidence it retrieves [14], yet it harms a measurable fraction of queries [1, 27]; cross-encoder reranking and pseudo-relevance feedback (PRF) are equally uneven. The natural response is to intervene selectively, and the natural gate is a query performance predictor (QPP): intervene when the current ranking looks like it is failing [2, 10]. That the gate's target differs from the quantity a policy needs is not new: selective-QE work predicts expansion benefit directly [6], and uplift modelling shows that targeting high-risk cases is not targeting the cases a treatment helps [3, 8]. What is missing is how much a failure gate gives up, why, and whether the telemetry a deployed system can observe, its *observability*, can do better.

Contributions. (C1) A decision framing of selective intervention under observable telemetry, with an exact decomposition of the gain no policy acting only on failing queries can capture, at zero and positive cost (Section 3). **(C2)** Its measurement for LLM QE, reranking, and PRF on four corpora, two pre-registered and untouched: the uncapped *failure-only ceiling* is 8–57% of the oracle's gain, failure scores rank helped queries weakly, and no pre-action predictor we test recovers the rest; eligibility and selection within it limit the gate together. **(C3)** Routing at matched budgets and measured cost, with partial probes of the intervention as a test of whether intervention-specific evidence changes the decision.

2 Related Work

QPP and selective QE. Pre- and post-retrieval QPP (Clarity [5], WIG [30], NQC [21]) predicts query difficulty. Cronen-Townsend et al. [6] compare the clarity of expanded and unexpanded rankings; Amati et al. [2] gate expansion on difficulty predictors; Lv and Zhai [15] predict a feedback weight; Collins-Thompson [4] trades reward against risk. Even idealised selective QE needs QPP at Kendall $\tau \geq 0.5$ [9]. Such work sizes predictor accuracy or evaluates gated systems; none bounds what a failure gate can recover or compares gates at matched budgets.

LLM QE and adaptive retrieval. Query2doc [26], MuGI [29], and CSQE [14] expand unconditionally; generative expansions often hurt strong retrievers [27] and fail on unfamiliar or ambiguous queries [1]. Kotte [11] gates prompt-only rewriting for dense retrievers without reliable gain. Sarode [19] finds that a learned selector over candidate LLM rewrites captures little oracle headroom and transfers inconsistently; we ask whether to intervene at all, across three interventions, and bound failure-restricted policies. Adaptive-RAG [10] routes on question complexity and Mallen et al. [17] retrieve only for less popular entities; cascade rankers [25] spend costly stages only on promising candidates, and cutoff and efficiency predictors [7, 23] set per-query reranking depth or pruning. In uplift terms [8], both outcomes are observed offline, so our label is exact up to relevance noise.

3 Framework

For a query q, let R_0 be the original ranking and R_a the ranking after intervention a, with metric M (nDCG@10). The intervention's effect is $\Delta_a(q) = M(R_a, q) - M(R_0, q)$ and its cost c_a ($\Delta_0 = c_0 = 0$). With full information the best decision is $a^*(q) = \arg\max_a\{\Delta_a(q) - \kappa c_a\}$, for a cost weight κ. A deployed controller sees only telemetry Z, so the best it can do is $\pi^*(Z) = \arg\max_a\{\mathbb{E}[\Delta_a \mid Z] - \kappa c_a\}$. What matters is therefore what Z reveals about Δ_a, not about $M(R_0)$. Two information sets differ in cost: *pre-action* telemetry Z_0 describes R_0 and costs no intervention, though computing it is not free; *post-action* telemetry Z_1 also describes R_a and exists only after c_a is paid. A *probe* observes part of the intervention, such as cross-encoder scores of a few candidates, at part of its cost (Section 9). A failure gate replaces $\mathbb{E}[\Delta_a \mid Z_0]$ with $P(F \mid Z_0)$, where $F = \mathbf{1}[M(R_0, q) = 0]$.

The failure-only ceiling. Fix one intervention with $c_a = 1$, so κ is its cost per query in nDCG@10 units. The oracle selector earns $G_{\text{orc}}(\kappa) = \mathbb{E}[(\Delta - \kappa)_+]$. A policy that may act only on failing queries does best by intervening where $F = 1$ and $\Delta > \kappa$, earning

$G_F^*(\kappa) = \mathbb{E}[F(\Delta - \kappa)_+]$, so

$$G_{\text{orc}}(\kappa) - G_F^*(\kappa) = \mathbb{E}[(1 - F)(\Delta - \kappa)_+]$$

(gain on healthy queries) bounds every failure-restricted policy at any $\kappa \geq 0$. Because $M \geq 0$, a failing query cannot be harmed ($\Delta \geq 0$ when $F = 1$), so at $\kappa = 0$ a *perfect* failure gate, intervening iff $F = 1$, attains G_F^*. At $\kappa > 0$ it earns $G_F(\kappa) = \mathbb{E}[F(\Delta - \kappa)]$, a further $\mathbb{E}[F(\kappa - \Delta)_+]$ below G_F^* spent on failing queries helped by less than κ, which only information beyond the binary label avoids. The identity is elementary; its use is that every term is measurable offline for any intervention. It does not bound a policy built from a failure *score* that also acts on healthy queries.

4 Setup

Data. TripClick [18]: 1.52M health documents, the TAIL bucket's validation and test splits (1,175 queries each), with click-derived relevance labels. BEIR NQ [12, 22]: 2.68M passages, human labels; 800 validation and a disjoint 2,052-query test set. BEIR ArguAna [24]: 8,674 arguments, 1,406 queries whose relevant document is the counterargument; BEIR FiQA [16]: 57,638 financial posts, official splits (Section 8).

Interventions. *LLM QE*: BM25 over SQLite FTS5; a deterministic rule picks one of four expansion operators or none, and `qwen2.5:3b` (4-bit, greedy, ≤ 2 calls) writes a corpus-grounded expansion. On TripClick and under dense retrieval (`bge-small-en-v1.5` [28]) the expanded ranking's top candidates are reranked by a MiniLM cross-encoder [20]; the original is not, so those labels include the reranker's effect. TripClick's deployed QE fuses original and expanded rankings (RRF); NQ's uses the expanded ranking. *Reranking*: the cross-encoder scores the BM25 top 100; its top 50 lead. *PRF*: RM3-style [13] weights from the top d documents select t terms whose BM25 ranking is interpolated with the original (weight λ); (d, t, λ) is tuned on validation over 108 settings.

Labels and models. *Failure*: $F = 1$ (45% of TripClick and 49% of NQ test queries under BM25). *Harmed*: $\Delta < 0$, ties not harmed. Detection is a logistic regression on 8 pre-action features (score shape, term coverage, rare-term IDF, entity overlap, coherence, perturbation stability; 6 under dense). Action utility is fit on Δ from post-action features. For pre-action routing, a *benefit* model regresses Δ on the 8 pre-action features alone. Every model and threshold is fit on validation and scored once on test; intervals are paired bootstraps over queries (10^4 resamples).

Evidence ledger. Only the ArguAna and FiQA results (Section 8) are independent confirmation: every NQ query and the TripClick TAIL test set have been inspected. *Fixed before a test run*: the NQ, reranking, and PRF runs. *Pre-committed analyses of inspected traces*: the AUCs, ceiling, budget routing, and Holm correction. *Exploratory*: TripClick test was used during development, the changed-query columns of Table 2 were added after seeing the main results, and the NQ B1/B2 runs, diagnostics, and probes of Section 9 followed protocols frozen before computing but after the test sets were inspected; the NQC probe contrasts, Spearman intervals, the positive-cost and budget-capped ceilings, same-target and within-failing AUCs, and P95 costing were added after review. Precommitments and scripts are in the anonymized repository: https://anonymous.4open.science/r/agentic-query-expansion-8939/.

Table 1: Failure-only ceiling (test). Rescue: $P(\Delta > 0 \mid F)$. Healthy helped / harmed: $P(\Delta \gtrless 0 \mid \neg F)$. Share: perfect failure gate's gain over the oracle's at $\kappa = 0$, 95% CI. ArguAna, FiQA: pre-registered, untouched test ($n = 430, 648$).

Setting	$P(F)$	Rescue	Healthy help / harm		Share
LLM QE, TripClick	.45	.07	.15	.19	42% [32, 52]
LLM QE, NQ	.49	.07	.19	.33	33% [26, 40]
LLM QE, TripClick, dense	.59	.06	.25	.41	34% [25, 43]
LLM QE, NQ, dense	.26	.15	.19	.29	33% [27, 40]
Reranking, TripClick	.45	.17	.24	.56	52% [44, 60]
Reranking, NQ	.49	.46	.55	.19	57% [54, 60]
PRF, TripClick	.45	.01	.12	.20	8% [1, 17]
PRF, NQ	.49	.05	.20	.22	32% [25, 39]
Reranking, ArguAna	.21	.36	.25	.53	38% [27, 49]
PRF, ArguAna	.21	.01	.05	.06	18% [0, 52]
LLM QE, ArguAna	.21	.27	.23	.59	39% [27, 52]
Reranking, FiQA	.51	.29	.52	.23	46% [39, 53]
PRF, FiQA	.51	.02	.14	.19	28% [11, 46]

5 The Failure-Only Ceiling

A perfect failure detector would capture 8–57% of the oracle's gain (Table 1; 18–46% on ArguAna and FiQA), though it never makes a query worse. The share follows how often an intervention rescues a failing query relative to how often it helps a healthy one: reranking rescues often (17% and 46% of failing queries), so half its headroom lies there; LLM QE rescues 6–15%; PRF on TripClick almost never (0.8%). The rest sits in healthy queries the intervention also often harms (19–56%), which only benefit prediction can separate.

Measured separately at $\kappa = 0.02$ (it can move either way), the best failure-restricted policy reaches 8–57% of the oracle's gain (22–47% on ArguAna and FiQA; per setting in the repository). Intervening on every failing query pays a further 0.004–0.011 and loses outright for PRF and dense TripClick QE.

Under a budget cap (exploratory, post-review) the restriction loosens only where rescues are common. At a 10% cap failing queries hold 98% [97, 99] of the capped oracle's gain for NQ reranking and 54–67% for the other reranking and ArguAna QE settings; the other seven stay within 0.06 of their uncapped share (8–43%), and from 25% all are within 0.004 of it but NQ reranking (80%; $\kappa = 0$, alike at 0.02); pre-registered FiQA agrees (reranking 46% $\rightarrow$ 83%, PRF 28% throughout). The gate also selects poorly, inside and outside the eligible set (35–80% of its 10% picks fail): it realises at most 34% of the restricted ceiling (24% of the capped oracle), loses in five settings at 10% (all three on ArguAna) and in 7–9 of 11 at 25–75%. Among failing queries its score ranks the rescued ones no better than chance: AUC 0.34–0.51, below 0.5 for NQ reranking and PRF and ArguAna QE and reranking, but 0.56 [0.49, 0.63] on pre-registered FiQA reranking, so not an inversion. Eligibility and selection limit failure routing together at every budget below 100%.

Which queries a failure gate picks. At a 25% budget (exploratory; categories prespecified, summaries chosen after review), 45–68% of failure routing's picks on TripClick and NQ (30–36% on ArguAna) are failing queries the intervention leaves unchanged, while healthy gains of at least 0.10 hold 42–83% of the oracle's gain. Each pre-action scorer's picks are helped within -0.11 to $+0.08$ of the base rate and capture 13–41% of the oracle selection's gain (random: 25–35%).

Table 2: Detection vs. action-utility AUC on the same test queries (LLM QE: acted-upon queries). Diff.: detection minus harm AUC, paired bootstrap; † not significant after Holm over the eight, ‡ over the three pre-registered ArguAna tests. $\Delta \neq 0$: detection minus direction (helped vs. harmed) on changed queries (exploratory; secondary pre-registered for ArguAna); * CI excludes 0. CIs in the repository.

Setting	Detection	Harm	Diff.	Diff., $\Delta \neq 0$
LLM QE, TripClick	0.643	0.552	+0.091	−0.044
LLM QE, NQ	0.675	0.556	+0.119	−0.041
LLM QE, TripClick, dense	0.621	0.599	+0.022†	+0.043
LLM QE, NQ, dense	0.695	0.611	+0.084	+0.122*
Reranking, TripClick	0.649	0.575	+0.075	+0.012
Reranking, NQ	0.680	0.514	+0.166	−0.025
PRF, TripClick	0.649	0.572	+0.077	+0.001
PRF, NQ	0.680	0.501	+0.179	−0.045
Reranking, ArguAna	0.646	0.570	+0.077‡	+0.045
PRF, ArguAna	0.646	0.319	+0.327	+0.458*
LLM QE, ArguAna	0.641	0.609	+0.032‡	−0.060

6 Detection vs. Action Utility

Detection is ordinary QPP. Detection AUC is 0.62–0.70; NQC [21] matches it on TripClick (0.647) and beats it on NQ (0.721 vs. 0.680).

Against the same label, it is weak. On whether the intervention helps ($\Delta > 0$; exploratory, post-review), the detector's AUC is 0.42–0.56 in all eleven settings (0.64–0.69 for failure on the same queries), its interval below 0.5 for NQ PRF and ArguAna QE and reranking and above only for dense NQ QE. Benefit scores, themselves weak (AUC $\leq$ 0.58; NQ probe 0.65), beat it on NQ reranking (+0.08 to +0.17, probe largest), NQ PRF, and ArguAna QE and reranking (+0.07 to +0.12); elsewhere differences span zero, but the linear model trails it on TripClick PRF (−0.06). NQC, a better failure detector on NQ, ranks helped queries worse on TripClick and NQ, better on ArguAna reranking (+0.04). Pre-registered on FiQA, the gap replicates: 0.72 for failure against 0.52 (reranking) and 0.46 (PRF), both Holm $p < 0.001$.

Its lead over harm prediction is structural. Detection beats harm AUC in seven of eight settings after Holm (Table 2), but failing queries cannot be harmed and are mostly unchanged, so the harm label is largely a failure indicator. On changed queries every TripClick and NQ BM25 gap vanishes; only dense NQ keeps one, and ArguAna PRF's rests on 38 queries.

7 Routing at Matched Budgets

Pre-action routing. At every budget, each scorer that decides before intervening stays close to random routing and far below the oracle (Table 3). Failure routing beats random by at most 0.006 at any budget and often falls below it (Figure 1). Averaged over budgets, NQC is no better than the detector, and benefit routing beats failure routing only for reranking on NQ (+0.009 [+0.003, +0.015]), where it leads at every budget (per-budget CIs in the repository). Boosted and embedding predictors (B1, B2; Section 8), fit on NQ validation (exploratory), do no better: none survives Holm, and the best recovers 8% of the oracle-minus-failure headroom. Failure routing can still save cost: for LLM QE, the deployed failure-selective policy halves generator calls and on NQ recovers most of unconditional QE's loss (+0.015 [+0.008, +0.022]); on TripClick no QE policy differs from BM25.

8 Pre-Registered Replications

ArguAna. To test the conclusions on data never inspected for this work, we pre-registered a run on BEIR ArguAna (counterargument retrieval) before downloading it: hypotheses, a debate-grouped split (701/275/430), the three interventions (LLM QE as on NQ), three new pre-action benefit predictors, and Holm-corrected primary contrasts. Each query is itself a corpus document, and 108 arguments are cross-listed under two ids; every search drops the query's own and text-identical documents, and duplicates share a split. These fixes, and three primary contrasts adopted from an externally written protocol, were dated amendments made before any label was read (`configs/arguana_precommit.json`). Predictors are fit on training queries, selected on validation, and scored once. B1, B3, and the failure router use 10 pre-action features (the 8 above, NQC, query length): B1 is LightGBM regression on Δ, B3 LightGBM quantile regression (its registered quantile choice by pinball loss is unsound, so a secondary B3 fixes 0.25). B2 is the distance-weighted mean Δ of the k nearest training queries under frozen `bge-small-en-v1.5` embeddings. Grids are in `scripts/54`.

On ArguAna every intervention loses on average (reranking −0.071 [−0.108, −0.034], LLM QE −0.163), yet the oracle could still gain 0.053 and 0.010 budget-averaged, so the question is purely one of selection. PRF barely acts here (nDCG@10 changes for 9% of queries), so its rows are uninformative. Pre-action routing again stays near random (Figure 1; budget-averaged table in the repository). For reranking, B1 minus failure routing is +0.015 [−0.001, +0.028] (Holm $p = 0.13$), B2 minus failure +0.008 (Holm $p = 0.37$), B3 minus B1 under a budget cap +0.006 ($p = 0.52$); the best recovers 16% of the oracle-minus-failure headroom, below the pre-registered 25% bar. Per budget, failure routing of reranking is below random at every budget and B1 above it (Figure 1); at 10%, 42% of the queries failure routing picks are harmed. A secondary pre-registered family (refit on train plus validation, wider grids) agrees: none of nine contrasts survives Holm. ArguAna is thus a hard, out-of-domain selection problem, not proof that pre-action prediction cannot work; B1's +0.015 may be real but unresolved at 430 queries.

FiQA. To test the post-review findings on data no analysis had touched, we pre-registered a second run on FiQA before downloading it (`configs/fiqa_precommit.json`): reranking and PRF under the ArguAna protocol, 1,500 training, 500 dev, and 648 test queries, the same runner, and one Holm family (six tests, five evaluable), with the probe prediction fixed from validation, where reranking helps (+0.10): probes should beat failure and B1 routing. The same-target gap replicates (Section 6); the within-failing inversion does not (0.56 [0.49, 0.63]; PRF, with 8 rescues, not evaluable). The probe predictions fail: Probe-10 minus failure routing is −0.001 [−0.009, +0.008] and minus B1 +0.006 [−0.001, +0.013] (Holm $p \geq 0.25$). B1 and B2 do not beat failure routing (−0.006 each, Holm $p = 0.19$), and detection beats harm AUC by +0.22 and +0.20.

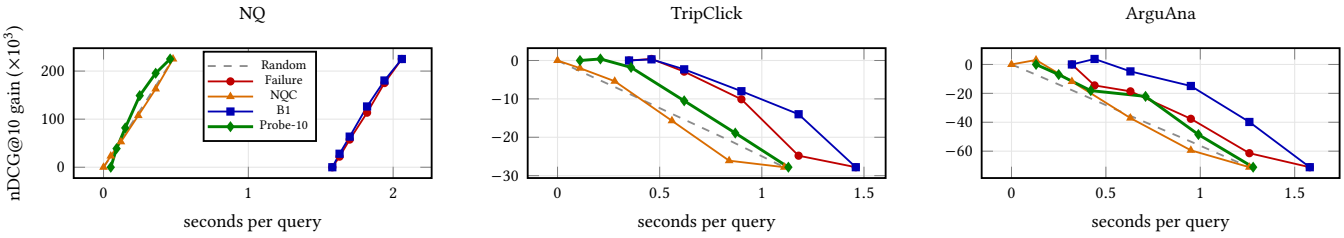


Figure 1: Reranking gain over BM25 against measured cost per query (exploratory) at 0–100% of queries reranked; cost is telemetry (Failure, B1, paid before deciding) or the probe, plus reranking. Oracle (off scale): 0.25, 0.06, 0.10.

Table 3: Pre-action routing gain (nDCG@10, $\times 10^3$) by share intervened on: failure (F), benefit (B), random (R, expected). Oracle and B−F [95% CI]: means over the five budgets (registered; Oracle can fall below All); * Holm-significant over the six settings.

	10%			25%			50%			75%			100%		
Setting	F	B	R	F	B	R	F	B	R	F	B	R	All	Oracle	B−F (avg.)
LLM QE, TripClick	3.5	1.2	0.1	3.0	−0.8	0.2	3.0	0.8	0.3	−1.5	1.0	0.5	0.7	19.7	−1.2 [−3.6, +1.4]
LLM QE, NQ	1.2	0.8	−2.2	−2.2	−1.2	−5.4	−5.9	−2.8	−10.8	−11.6	−12.6	−16.3	−21.7	28.4	+0.6 [−2.0, +2.9]
Rerank, TripClick	0.3	0.3	−2.8	−3.1	−0.8	−6.9	−10.1	−8.6	−13.9	−24.8	−19.7	−20.8	−27.8	40.5	+1.8 [−3.7, +6.3]
Rerank, NQ	22.1	32.6	22.5	57.6	66.9	56.3	113.5	129.2	112.5	175.1	183.7	168.8	225.1	199.5	+8.8 [+3.3, +15.0]*
PRF, TripClick	−0.7	0.3	−0.1	−0.2	0.7	−0.3	0.5	−0.2	−0.6	−0.5	−1.1	−0.8	−1.1	9.6	+0.1 [−1.0, +1.0]
PRF, NQ	0.1	0.2	1.0	1.4	1.2	2.4	3.9	5.7	4.9	7.5	7.6	7.3	9.7	24.0	+0.4 [−1.7, +2.4]

9 Partial Observation and Cost

A probe sits between pre- and post-action telemetry. In an exploratory analysis (protocol frozen before computing), we score only the first $k \in \{5, 10, 20\}$ BM25 candidates ($k = 10$ primary, fixed in the protocol) with the cross-encoder, regress the Δ of full reranking on nine probe features with B1's model and selection rule, and fully rerank the top-scoring queries, reusing the probe's scores. Each policy is charged its median measured latency (50 validation queries per corpus; Figure 1): full reranking takes 0.48, 1.11, and 1.26 s on NQ, TripClick, and ArguAna, a ten-candidate probe 0.05–0.13 s.

On NQ, where reranking usually helps (Figure 1), Probe-10 routing beats failure routing by +0.024 [+0.017, +0.031] and B1 by +0.017 [+0.011, +0.022] over 10–75% reranked (both Holm-significant over the six primary tests), and its predictions rank Δ best (Spearman 0.25 [0.21, 0.29]; B1 0.09, NQC −0.06). NQ's pre-action telemetry (a perturbation search over 2.68M passages) takes longer than reranking every query, so always reranking dominates failure and B1 routing. Against free NQC (post-review), probe routing gains +0.030 [+0.022, +0.037] at matched fraction and +0.020 [+0.012, +0.028] at equal median-latency cost (both Holm-significant over six NQC contrasts), +0.010 [+0.002, +0.018] at P95. On TripClick and ArguAna, where reranking loses on average, probes do not help: no matched-fraction contrast is significant, and B1 ranks Δ at least as well (Spearman 0.08 and 0.10 vs. 0.05; differences span zero); nor on FiQA, where it helps (Section 8).

Robustness (secondary, uncorrected). Every probe size beats failure and B1 on NQ, none differs from either on TripClick, and on ArguAna Probe-5 trails B1 (−0.023). On TripClick the probe leads NQC at equal cost (+0.007 [+0.000, +0.013], Holm $p = 0.18$), close to its matched-fraction lead (+0.005, n.s.).

10 Discussion and Limitations

Two kinds of result show that failure is the wrong routing target. One is proven for failure-restricted policies: at any cost, they are capped by the oracle gain on failing queries (8–57% uncapped, at $\kappa = 0$ and 0.02). The other is empirical, for these representations, models, and corpora: against the benefit label failure scores are weak, the pre-action predictors we test pick helped queries at about their base rate, and failure routing spends a substantial fraction of its budget where the intervention does nothing. The second alone would fit 'no pre-action signal we test predicts benefit'; the first is what makes failure specifically the wrong target. Both limits coexist: the restriction excludes healthy gains, the gate selects poorly among failing queries, and small caps loosen only the first, for rescue-rich interventions. For these systems only, always rerank on NQ and FiQA when affordable and skip it on TripClick and ArguAna.

Limitations. One small (3B) generator; reranking and PRF only under BM25, with one cross-encoder and one PRF family. Four corpora, two untouched (430 and 648 test queries), underpowered for differences below about 0.015; under dense retrieval, retriever strength and domain are confounded, and the dense QE labels include the reranker. TripClick's labels are click-derived and sparse. The cost weight κ is illustrative, latencies are single-machine (median, P95 check), and probes cover reranking only. All pre-committed results are reported.

11 Conclusion

A controller acting only on failing queries gets at most the oracle's gain on them (8–57% uncapped), and a failure gate selects poorly even among them; its score ranks helped queries at AUC 0.42–0.56, replicated on untouched FiQA. Selective-intervention work should report failure-only ceilings and cost-aware routing curves, not only AUC.

Ethical Considerations

All data (TripClick, BEIR NQ, ArguAna, and FiQA) are existing research benchmarks used under their licenses; TripClick is used for non-commercial research, and no model or per-query output fit on it is released. TripClick's click logs are aggregate, de-identified interactions, and we make no attempt to re-identify searchers. No human-subjects data was collected. The generator is a small, locally hosted model used only to rewrite queries within a bounded action space. Our central finding cautions against deploying generative interventions on the strength of a failure detector alone.

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